

The Galápagos



THE GALÁPAGOS ISLANDS lie in the Pacific Ocean, about 600 miles (1,000 km) west of South America. They are home to a great variety of unique and unusual animals, which swam, flew, or drifted across to the islands

from the Americas. Few mammals managed this crossing, so the islands are dominated by birds and reptiles, such as iguanas and giant tortoises.

In 1835, British naturalist Charles Darwin observed animals on the islands and came up with the theory of evolution, which states that over many generations animals change (evolve) to suit their habitat.

Useless wings

The ancestor of the flightless cormorant flew to the Galápagos, but today its wings are only one-third of the size they would have to be to support it in flight. Before humans settled on the islands, cormorants had no enemies there it needed to fly away from. Its feathers are also not waterproof, so after diving underwater to catch fish, it spreads out its wings to dry in the sun.

Flightless cormorant
(*Phalacrocorax harrisi*)
Length: up to 3 ft 3 in
(1 m)

ISLA PINTA

ISLA MARCHENA

ISLA GENOVESA

FLIGHTLESS CORMORANT

Wolf Volcano



Underwater volcanoes formed the Galápagos Islands, which are made of volcanic lava.

Darwin Volcano

GALÁPAGOS PENGUIN

SALLY LIGHTFOOT CRAB

ISLA SAN SALVADOR

The smaller Galápagos Islands are largely waterless and few plants can survive.

ISLA FERNANDINA

La Cumbre Volcano



LAND IGUANA

Alcedo Volcano

P A C I F I C
O C E A N

GALÁPAGOS FUR SEAL

WOODPECKER FINCH

ISLA SANTA CRUZ

LITTLE VERMILION FLYCATCHER

GIANT TORTOISE

ISLA SANTA FÉ

I S L A

I S A B E L A

Santo Tomás Volcano

MARINE IGUANA

KILOMETERS
0 5 10 15 20
MILES
0 5 10 15

Fearless footwork

Large numbers of Sally Lightfoot crabs live on the rocky shores of the Galápagos. The crab has a hard shell for protection. As it grows, it sheds its shell from time to time and grows a larger one. The crab runs sideways because its legs are jointed from the side of its body. Its front legs have developed into a pair of pincers for grasping food.

Sally Lightfoot crab
(*Grapsus grapsus*)
Width of shell: up to 3 in (8 cm)

Land iguana
(*Conolophus subcristatus*)
Length: up to 3 ft 11 in
(1.2 m)

Fighting males

During the mating season, the male land iguana defends his territory against other males. If a rival approaches, he bobs his head in a ritual display to warn the intruder to keep away. If this does not work, a fight may break out, with the iguanas trying to bite each other with their strong teeth. They rarely fight to the death, though, and the weaker male usually retreats when he realizes he cannot win.

ISLA SANTA MARÍA